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DISCOVER 101

Is Your Problem Worth Solving?

Sharpen your problem, test your assumptions, and get the truth from customers.

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Meet the Team



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Agenda

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What is Customer Discovery and Its Importance

What it is and why skipping it costs you.

Problem Definition

Naming a problem customers recognize.

Who Has This Problem? (Your ICP)

Who feels the pain most.

Talking to Customers

Get the truth, not compliments.

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What is Customer Discovery and Its Importance

What it is and why skipping it costs you.

What Customer Discovery Actually Is

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A systematic way to validate your customers' real needs before you build.

How It Works in Practice

A repeatable framework, not a quick survey to friends.

💬**Interviews:** Structured talks about behaviour.

👁️**Observation:** Watch them in their real context.

✅**Validation:** Confirm needs, don't assume.

Why It Matters Tremendously

Keeps you from building what no one wants.

💰**Saves Capital:** Test risky assumptions before code.

🧠**Uncovers Truth:** Find the root problem.

📈**Path to PMF:** Build for how users really work.

Why Customer Discovery Matters

Skipping discovery is a top reason startups fail.

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⚠️ **42%**

of Failed Startups

No Market Need

Make sure customers actually care (CB Insights).

💡 **Far**

Cheaper to Pivot Early

Capital Efficiency

Changing a prototype costs a fraction of rewriting code.

🎯 **10**

Conversations to Start With

Faster Product-Market Fit

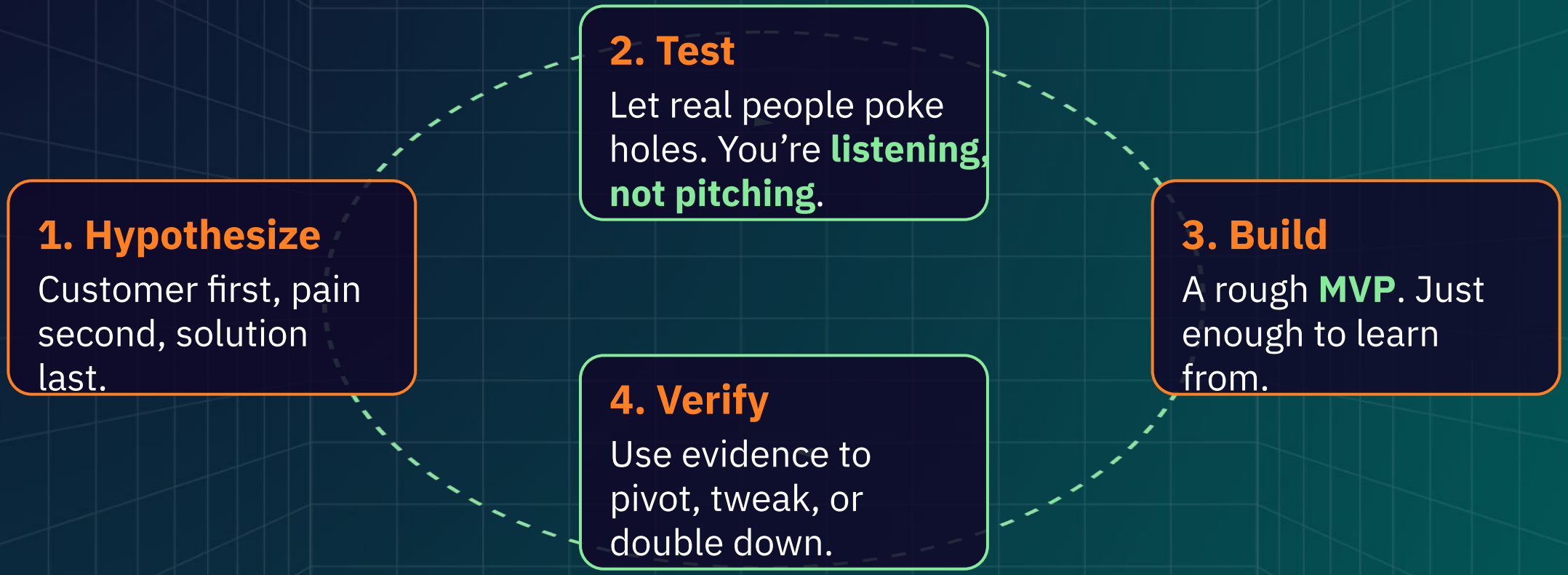
Real conversations align your team on needs, messaging, and features.

🧭 **Discovery isn’t one-and-done — it guides every decision.**

Four Phases of Customer Discovery

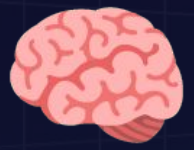
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A loop: listen, learn, iterate.



It's a circle, not a finish line.

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Problem Definition

Naming a problem customers recognize.

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“Customers don’t buy products, they buy solutions to problems.”

What does this quote really mean?

People buy outcomes, not features. They want to save time, save money, or remove a pain.

Understand the problem first; the value follows.

The Importance of a Problem

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Show the pain and its real impact. **Ask:**

💰 Costing them money?

Is there a direct financial cost?

⏱️ Wasting their time?

How many hours are lost?

🧠 How does it make them feel?

Frustrated, anxious, stuck?

How the Problem Informs Your Strategy

1. Clarifies Your Focus

Tells you which assumptions to test first.

2. Guides Your Hypotheses

Turns problems into testable bets.

Example: "We believe business owners lose 2+ hours/week tracking cash flow by hand."

3. Shapes Your Interviews

Tells you what to test, with whom, and why.

Problem vs. Solution Traps

Three ways founders blur the problem.

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TRAP 01

Solution in Disguise

“We need an app to track spending.”

FIX:
Name the pain, not the product.

TRAP 02

Too Broad to Test

“Healthcare is inefficient.”

FIX:
Narrow it to one person, one moment.

TRAP 03

Assuming the Pain

“It bugs me, so it bugs everyone.”

FIX:
Check if anyone pays for a workaround.

⚡ **Quick check:** Remove your product. Does the problem still stand?

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Who Has This Problem? (Your ICP)

Who feels the pain most.

Your Ideal Customer Profile (ICP)

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Not everyone with the problem. The people who feel it most, right now.

Start With the Problem

Define them by their pain, not your product.

Ask: who loses the most time, money, or sleep over this?

Behaviour First

“Women 25-40” is not an ICP.

Focus on what they search for, try, and do.

Find the Overlap

They know the problem, tried to fix it, and are still looking.

Your early adopters. Interview them first.

Try it: “My first customer is ___ who is trying to ___. Today they ___, and that’s not working because ___.”

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Talking to Customers

Get the truth, not compliments.



3 Rules from The Mom Test

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01

Talk about their life, not your idea.

The moment you pitch, they start being polite.

02

Ask about specifics in the past, not opinions about the future.

“Last time” beats “would you.”

03

Talk less, listen more.

Compliments aren’t data. Commitments (time, an intro, money) are.

Customer Discovery: Right vs. Wrong Questions

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INSTINCTIVE FOUNDER QUESTIONS

Hypothetical, leading, or binary.

THE HYPOTHETICAL

"Would you use an app that helps with budgeting?"

THE LEADING

"Don't you think tracking expenses is a pain?"

THE FUTURE INTENT

"Would you pay for something that solved this?"

TRAINED INTERVIEWER QUESTIONS

Past-tense, open-ended, and behavior-focused.

PAST EXPERIENCE

"Tell me about the last time you were surprised by your account balance."

CURRENT WORKAROUND

"How do you currently keep track of your spending?"

ATTEMPTED SOLUTIONS

"What have you already tried to solve this? What happened?"

AI Across Your Discovery Process

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Where AI actually helps, from first research to making sense of what you heard.

Research

BEFORE YOU START

Size the market and map competitors and existing alternatives.

Try: Perplexity, ChatGPT deep research

Prep

BEFORE THE CALL

Draft open-ended questions and role-play a skeptical customer.

Try: Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini

Capture

DURING THE CALL

Record and transcribe so you can listen instead of typing notes.

Try: Otter, Fireflies, Granola

Synthesize

AFTER THE CALL

Spot patterns and pull quotes across all your interviews.

Try: NotebookLM, Dovetail

THE GOLDEN RULE

AI can organize what customers say, but it can't say it for them. Use it to prepare and make sense of conversations, never to replace them. Always ask permission before recording a call.

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